

Verb-driven Patterns of Object Omission in the History of Spanish: A Corpus-based Analysis

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1. Introduction

Spanish DO omission remains underexplored with regards to its semantic and syntactic distribution in comparison to Portuguese:

	Port.	Spa.		Port.	Spa.
indefinite NOs	✓	(✓)	VP ellipsis	✓	(X) ?
definite NOs	✓	(X) ?	NOs in MC	✓	(X) ?
inanimate NOs	✓	(✓) ?	NOs in coord.	✓	(✓) ?
animate NOs	(X)	(✓) ?	NOs in islands	(✓)	(✓) ?

a. ¿Compraste café? – Sí, compré. (Campos 1986)

‘Did you buy coffee? – Yes, I bought ø’

¿Pedro traerá cerveza a la fiesta? – Su novia dijo que traería.

‘Will Pedro bring beer to the party? – His girlfriend said he would bring ø’

b. *Juan les leía libros a los niños y Ana también leía. (Cyrino 2019)

‘Juan read books to the children and Ana did, too.’

Important theoretical questions concerning NOs:

Peninsular Spanish:

- How should NOs in imperatives and short answers be treated?
- What is the syntactic status of a NO?
 - an empty syntactic category, licensed through binding?
 - an understood argument, licensed through entrenchment?

Across Iberoromance:

- Why do Spanish and Portuguese diverge in the licensing of NOs?
- Are Spanish and Portuguese NOs comparable structures?

→ Potential answers through diachronic analysis?

2. Previous Diachronic Accounts

The Object Agreement Cycle (OAC)

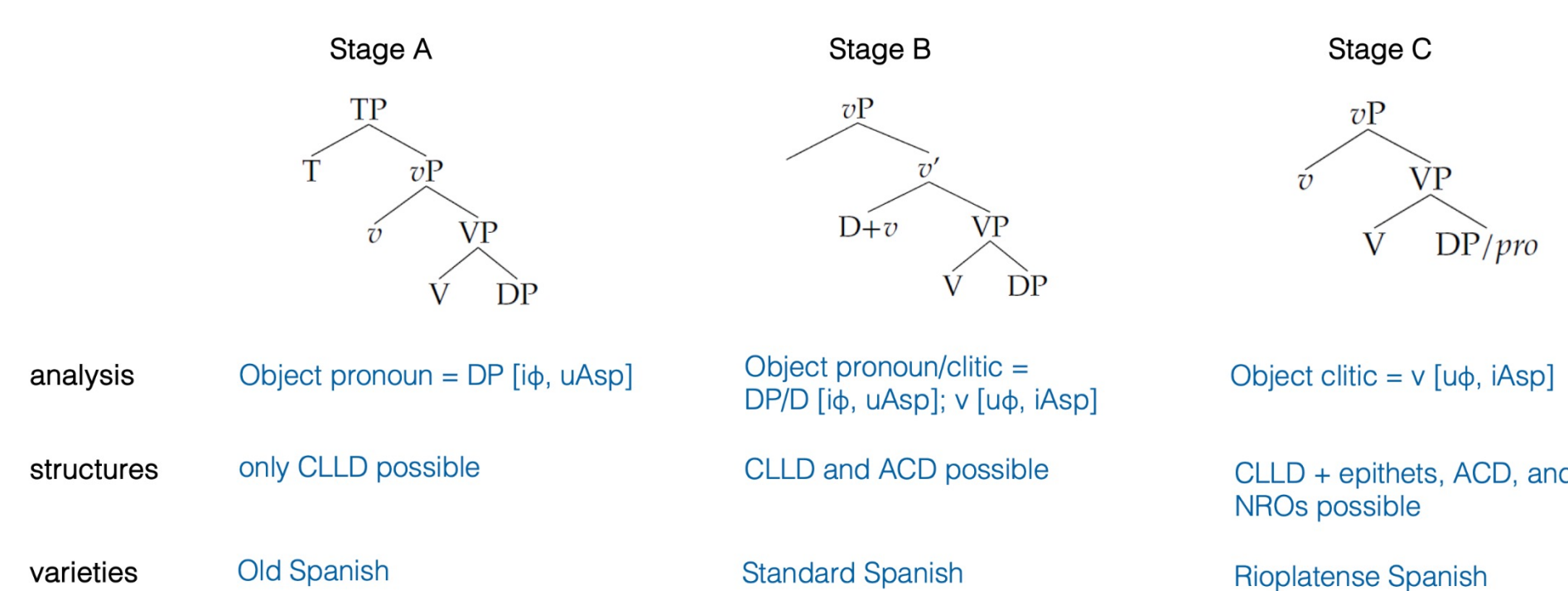


Figure: Overview of the OAC

Main claims:

- NO only possible in languages that license accusative clitic doubling (ACD) → NOs possible in Rioplatense, but not in Peninsular Spanish
- Delay between the emergence of DCD and ACD

Innovation:

- Diachronic analysis based on empirical data
- Connects clitic doubling (CD) and NOs as options of DO realisation

However:

- No clear definitions of NOs
- Inaccurate predictions for Portuguese despite cross-linguistic claims
- No discussion of syntactic or semantic constraints of NOs

→ Need for large-scale empirical analysis on ACD and NOs in Spanish

3. Research Questions

- How has direct object omission and accusative clitic doubling evolved in Spanish over time?
- Can verbs (lexical semantics) predict DO omission?

4. Corpus & Methodology

Objective: Analysis of Spanish DO realisation from XII – XVIII

Corpus data: custom compilation from selected texts

- As close to spoken text as possible (cantares, plays, prose including direct speech)
- Size of subcorpora: between 40.000 and 250.000 words

Target structures: transitive sentences based on 40-60 selected verbs

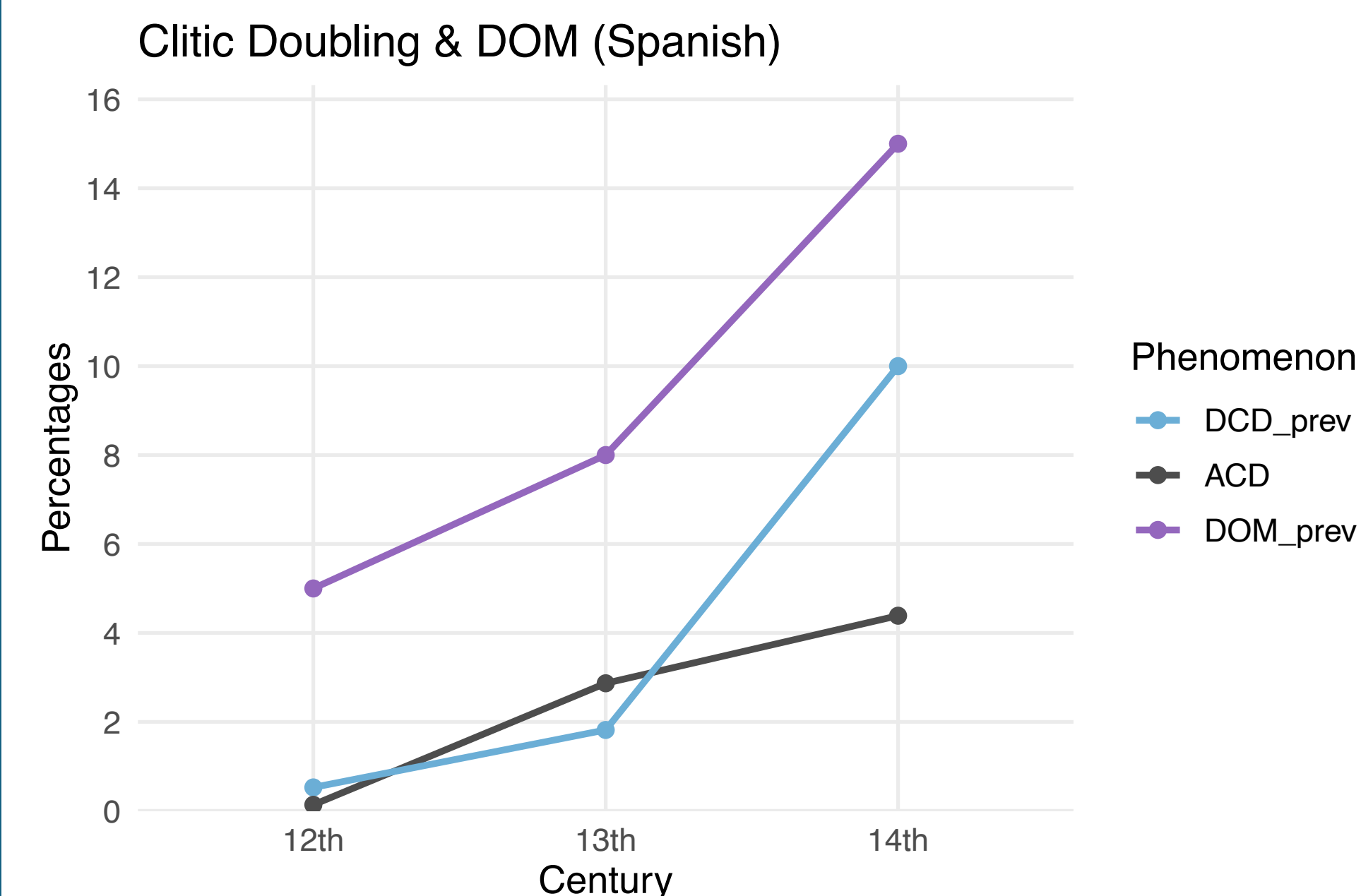
- Verbs with highest frequencies within each subcorpus
- Verbs with overall diachronic stability and continuity
- Inclusion of both monotransitives and ditransitives

Extraction and annotation:

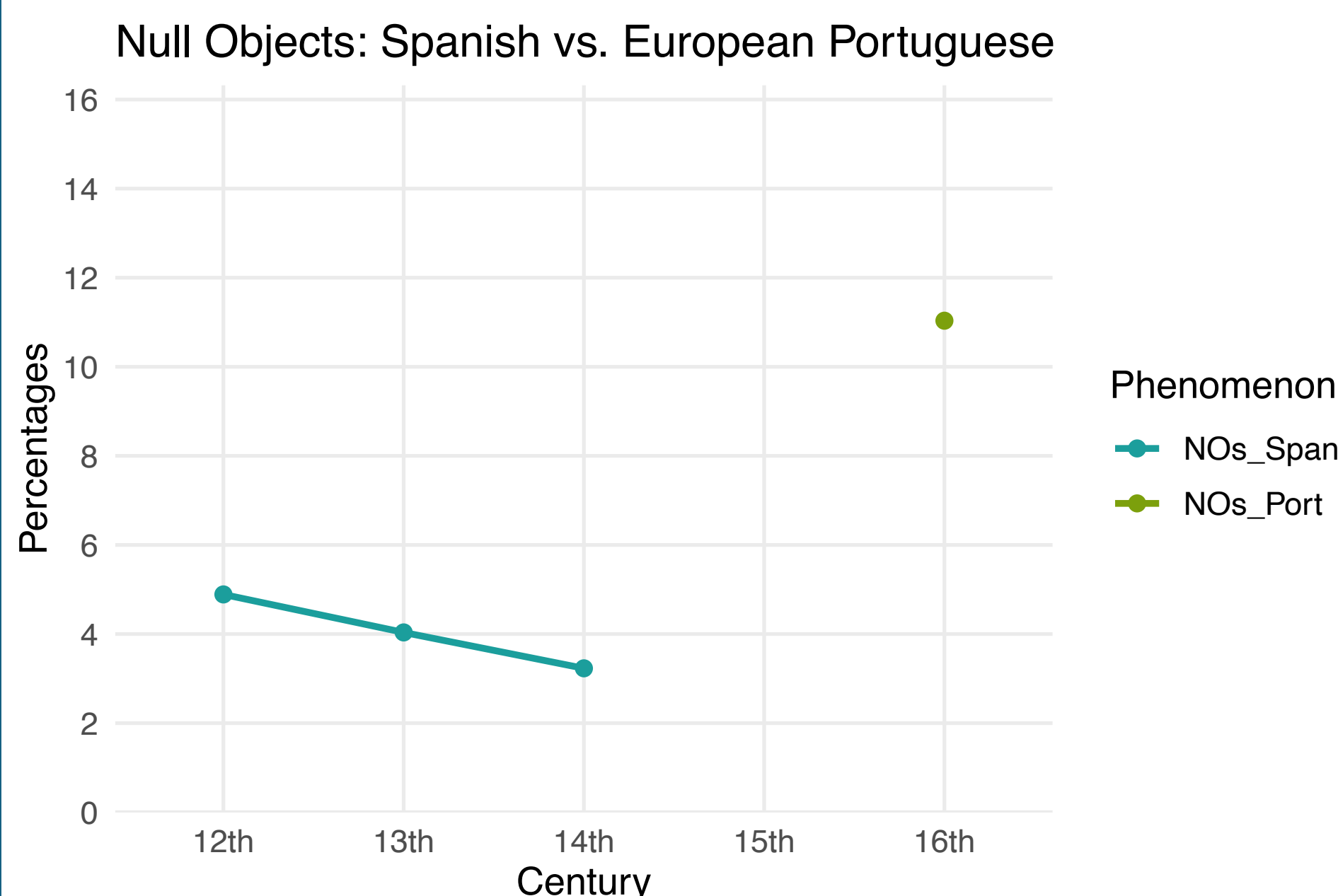
- (Semi-)automised extraction and preparation:
 - SketchEngine/CQL and Python/SpaCy
- Manual checks and coding:
 - removal of negative hits (pass., reflex., causat., etc.)
 - coding of
 - DO realisation/omission
 - NO type: referential, propositional
 - related phenomena: CD, DOM
 - presence/absence of referential adverb: así, ya, etc.

5. Preliminary Results (ct. XII-XIV)

- Between 1100 and 1600 eligible tokens coded for each century



- Virtually no doubling of any objects up until the 13th century
- ACD emerges at around the same time as DCD → challenge to OAC
- However, DCD increases considerably from 14th century onwards



- NOs appear to be more frequent at older stages of Spanish
- Overall lack of data on contemporary distributions in Spanish
- European Portuguese: lack of mediaval data
- NOs must, however, have increased considerably in Portuguese (11% → 40%, XVI-XX, Cyrino 1997)

→ Overall: increase of CD vs decrease of NOs in Spanish

6. A Closer Look at the Data

Accusative Clitic Doubling (ACD)

- Evidence for incipient CD of DOs through resumptive clitics → “true” accusative clitic doubling?
- Interestingly, mainly ACD of nominal NPs at older stages

a. ¡Agora las ayan quitas heredades de Carrión! [#ID36154]

‘Now may they have the estates of Carrión taken from them!’

b. Non lo saben los moros el ardiment que an. [#ID5329]

‘The Moors don’t know the bravery they have.’

c. Nos bien la sabemos aquesta rrazón que [#ID31418]

‘We know full well this plea that the Cid Campeador puts forward justly.’

Null Objects (NOs)

- About as many referential as propositional NOs (XII-XIV)

d. el espada tomó & rreçibió. [#ID31099]

‘He took the sword and received ø [him]’

- Observed co-occurrence of Nos with adverbs as referential anchors

e. e fizo assí ...e mató. [#ID40023]

‘And so he did ... and killed ø [him]’

- Low verb type frequencies: small group of verbs in NO tokens

- Expectation of strong verb class effects

- CONSUMPTION, COMMUNICATION, ACTIVITY, PERCEPTION

- interesting: data includes verbs usually known to disfavour NOs

e.g. verbs expressing HIGH TRANSITIVITY

f. demonyado, e echo de su cuerpo [#ID47984]

‘Possessed by a demon, and he cast ø [it] out from his body.’

g. salieron dos osos de la montaña, e mataron. [#ID69781]

‘Two bears came out from the mountains, and they killed ø [them].’

- Possibility of VP ellipsis at older stages of Spanish?

h. quisieron los magos fer esso e non podieron. [#ID40362]

‘The magicians wished to do that, but they couldn’t’

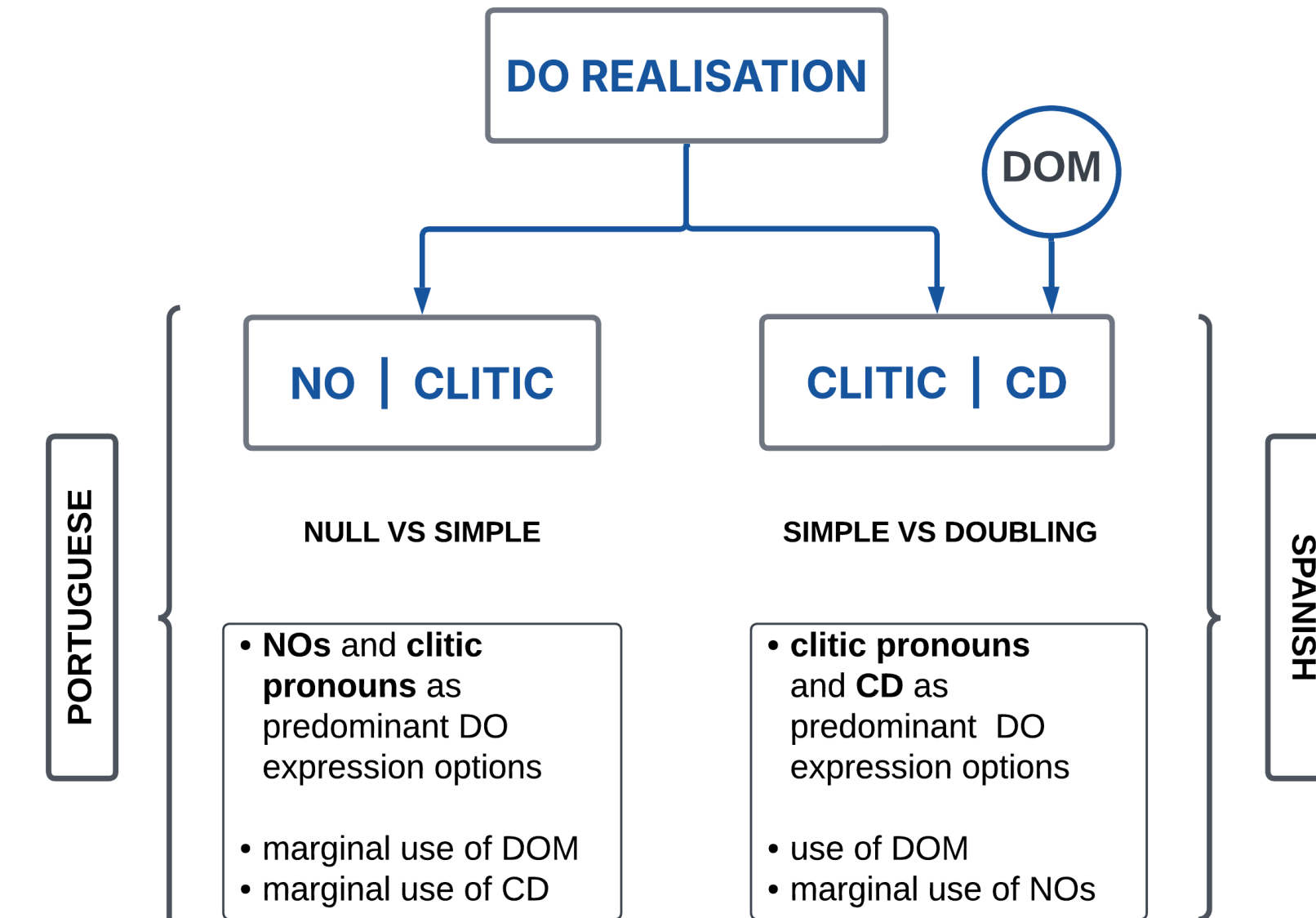
i. non quiso so padre, e dixo. [#ID57702]

‘His father would not ø [engage], and said ø [it]’

7. Discussion and Integration

→ NOs as a **variant of direct object realisation** next to (clitic) pronouns, marked objects (DOM) and CD?

- What causes the divergence between Spanish and Portuguese?
 - absence of Class 3 psych verbs in Portuguese?
 - advanced syncretism in Spanish (e.g. leísmo)?



8. Next Steps

- Further annotation and coding
 - remaining Spanish data (XV – XVII), extension to Portuguese?
 - semantics of referential NOs (animacy, definiteness)

→ Statistical analysis to verify or discard current intuitions

